

Buying Property in Cebu

A step-by-step checklist for first-time buyers and OFW families.

Last reviewed: September 2026

General information only

This checklist is a starting point, not legal, tax, or financial advice. Laws, fees, and government procedures change and vary by city. Confirm the details for your own deal with a lawyer, the BIR, the local Registry of Deeds, and the city or municipal offices involved.

1. Before you start shopping

- ☐ Set a total budget, not just a price: add closing costs (taxes, transfer and registration fees, notarial fees) and moving-in costs.
- ☐ Decide the purpose: a home to live in, a rental or investment, or a business space. It changes what "good" looks like.
- ☐ Choose how you will pay: cash, bank loan, Pag-IBIG housing loan, or developer financing. Ask about pre-approval before you fall in love with a unit.
- ☐ Write your must-haves and deal-breakers: bedrooms, lot or floor area, commute, schools, parking, flood-free access.
- ☐ Shortlist areas. Compare 2-3 neighborhoods on price per square metre, travel time, and future developments.

Buying from abroad (OFW families)

You can do most of this remotely. Ask for video viewings, and if you need someone to sign or transact for you, use a properly executed and notarized Special Power of Attorney (SPA) prepared with a lawyer, and processed for use abroad as required (apostille or consularization). Keep proof of your income and remittances handy for loan applications.

2. Viewing checklist

The site and neighborhood

- ☐ Ask neighbors or the barangay about flooding, especially after heavy rain. Look for water marks on walls and gates.
- ☐ Check road access, drainage, and whether the street floods or is prone to traffic at rush hour.
- ☐ Confirm water source and pressure, electricity, internet options, and mobile signal.
- ☐ Visit at different times of day (morning, evening, weekend) to judge noise and traffic.
- ☐ For subdivisions and condos, ask about monthly association or condo dues and what they cover.

The house or unit

- ☐ Look for roof leaks, wall cracks, damp patches, termite damage, and uneven floors.
- ☐ Test faucets, drains, water heater, switches, outlets, and the electrical panel.
- ☐ Open every door and window. Check locks, gates, and fences.
- ☐ For condos: elevators, parking allocation, fire exits, building maintenance, and the unit's orientation.

- ☐ Take photos and notes at each viewing so you can compare properly later.

3. Verify the property and the seller

This is the step that protects your money. Do not pay a reservation or down payment until the basics below check out.

- ☐ Ask for a copy of the title (TCT for house and lot, CCT for condo). The name on it should match the seller's valid ID.
- ☐ Get a Certified True Copy of the title from the Registry of Deeds to confirm it is authentic and to see any annotations: mortgage, adverse claim, lis pendens, or other liens.
- ☐ If the seller is not the registered owner, require a valid written authority (for example an SPA) and verify it. If the owner has passed away, ask for the extrajudicial settlement of estate and proof the estate tax was dealt with.
- ☐ If the property is co-owned or conjugal, all owners (and spouse, where required) must sign.
- ☐ Check the latest Tax Declaration and proof that real property tax is paid up to date. Ask for a tax clearance.
- ☐ Confirm boundaries. Compare the title's technical description with the lot on the ground, and consider a relocation survey by a geodetic engineer.
- ☐ Ask who occupies the property and whether it will be delivered vacant.
- ☐ Check the zoning or land-use classification with the city planning office if you plan to build, renovate, or run a business. Agricultural land may need conversion clearances before it can be used otherwise.
- ☐ For condos: request the Master Deed and Declaration of Restrictions, house rules, and a certificate showing no unpaid dues.

Buying pre-selling or new-development units

Ask to see the developer's License to Sell and Certificate of Registration issued by DHSUD (Department of Human Settlements and Urban Development, formerly HLURB), plus the project's development permit. Check the developer's track record on completed projects, the promised turnover date, and what happens if it slips. If you pay in installments, ask a lawyer how the Maceda Law (RA 6552) protections apply to your contract. For any "assume balance" or resale of rights, get the developer's written approval of the transfer.

4. Making the deal

- ☐ Put your offer in writing, with the price, payment terms, what is included (fixtures, parking, furniture), and the turnover date.
- ☐ Get an official receipt for any reservation fee, and know in writing whether it is refundable and under what conditions.
- ☐ Have a lawyer review the Contract to Sell (installments) or the Deed of Absolute Sale (full payment) before you sign.
- ☐ Use traceable payments (bank transfer or manager's check) and get a receipt every time. Avoid large cash handovers.
- ☐ Agree in writing who pays which closing costs. It is negotiable, and disputes here are common.

5. Closing costs and transfer, in plain steps

The exact amounts and who pays depend on your deal. As a rough map of what usually happens:

- **Taxes and fees to expect:** capital gains tax (usually paid by the seller), documentary stamp tax, local transfer tax, Registry of Deeds registration fee, and notarial fees. Rates and computation bases (selling price vs. zonal value vs. assessed value) change, so confirm current rules with the BIR and the city treasurer.
- **Step 1:** Sign and notarize the Deed of Absolute Sale.
- **Step 2:** Pay the applicable taxes to the BIR and secure the Certificate Authorizing Registration (CAR / eCAR).
- **Step 3:** Pay the transfer tax at the city or municipal treasurer's office.
- **Step 4:** Register the deed with the Registry of Deeds so a new title is issued in your name.
- **Step 5:** Have the tax declaration transferred at the city or municipal assessor's office.

6. Financing paperwork (typical)

- ☐ Two valid government IDs, TIN, and proof of civil status.
- ☐ Proof of income: payslips or certificate of employment, income tax return, bank statements. Self-employed buyers usually need business documents.
- ☐ For OFWs: employment contract, proof of remittances, and your SPA if someone will transact for you.
- ☐ For Pag-IBIG loans: active membership and contribution record. Requirements and loan limits change, so check the current rules.
- ☐ Ask the lender about the property appraisal, the loan-to-value ratio, and required insurance.

7. Before you move in

- ☐ Do a final walkthrough and list every defect to be fixed before turnover. Take photos.
- ☐ Receive and safely keep the original documents: title, tax declaration, contract, and all receipts.
- ☐ Transfer utility accounts and note the meter readings on the day of turnover.
- ☐ Notify the homeowners' association or condo administration and settle any move-in requirements.
- ☐ Arrange property insurance (fire and other risks).

Red flags: slow down or walk away if you see these

The seller will not show the title or a certified copy. The price is far below similar listings. You are pressured to pay in cash today. The seller's name does not match the title and there is no authority document. The title has annotations nobody can explain. The seller refuses a notarized contract or official receipts.

Want a second pair of eyes?

If you are considering a property in Cebu City, Talisay City, or nearby, message me and I will help you shortlist, arrange viewings, and go through this checklist with you. For legal and tax questions, always involve a lawyer.